

CREATING LOCAL LINKAGES

WHAT IS LOCAL HISTORY?

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Local history is about a place. All historical writing involves places, but they generally serve as a backdrop or setting that is incidental to accounts that focus on a particular process, event, group or individual. By contrast, a place is at the center of local history. A place is more than simply a geographic area defined by coordinates on a map; it is a locale in which people conduct their lives and which they have invested with meaning, become attached to and named.¹

Local history is about a place small in scale, typically a county, town, or a neighborhood within a city, rather than a state, or region. Zooming in to this level brings into focus individuals who do not feature in national and global stories. At the same time, the limited geographic scale makes it possible to examine the broad range of topics that constitute those individuals' everyday lives, and the material structures and environmental landscapes that shaped their experiences of the world.²

Local history's focus on individuals is different from genealogy; it is concerned not just with the relations that constitute a family tree, but with individuals as part of a community. However, the two approaches share common sources, which are often grouped together in public library departments. That organization reflects a situation in which local histories have been regarded as sources for genealogical information. However, there is growing interest in expanding family trees into family histories that include information about how and where past generations lived, spurred in part by genealogy television shows in which historians resolve the puzzles and contradictions in the sources and explain the contexts of an ancestor's life. Such family histories require and contribute to the history of a place, rather than simply searching local history for names.³ An individual's identity and experience is shaped by where they are, and their lives shape the meaning of that place.⁴

Academic historians too have become more interested in the lives of ordinary individuals. Early social historians used genealogical sources such as census schedules and probate records to document large-scale patterns in population, mortality, literacy, or employment among ordinary people.⁵ In recent years, aided by

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the proliferation of searchable digital collections, they have turned to the same sources to track the life stories of ordinary individuals to gain a different perspective on those changes, and on what control non-elite individuals had over their lives. British historian Tim Hitchcock characterizes this form of 'history from below' as using "detail and empathy to demand of readers a personal engagement with a specific time and place," and with "individual men and women caught in a whirl of larger historical changes."⁶ What continues to distinguish academic history from local history is a concern with the arguments of other historians and with debates among historians about how to interpret what happened.⁷

Local history is about a place of which the historian is a part. Kyvig & Marty use the term "Nearby History" to highlight that local history explores the history close at hand, the "entire range of possibilities in a person's immediate environment," families, communities, and built environments.⁸ Being a part of the place that is your subject gives you access to a rich range of sources, not only documents, but material objects and landscapes, as Rebecca Onion notes:

The go-to mode of engagement for people interested in history is often reading—as my groaning bookshelves can attest. There's so much text out there to absorb, and it can be tempting to stay indoors and absorb it. But in the months when I challenged myself to find out more about local history, I sat next to a remarkable slab of rock; saw the sunset from a new vantage point, in a cemetery I'd walked past many times but never ventured into; and started looking at roadside plants in a different way.⁹

That connection to your subject also creates challenges. A local history risks becoming an insider's history, focused on milestones, continuity and successes, and ignoring failures and conflicts. It can become romantic and conservative, including only the early settlers, the wealthy and powerful members of a community, and events that can be commemorated, and used to promote a place. In the same way, a focus on a small place can narrow to exclude any attention to surrounding places, and to larger regions, events, and processes to which a local community was connected.¹⁰

To avoid those pitfalls requires formulating questions that will unveil a more complete picture of the past. Defining a topic and developing questions are the first steps in the process of historical research: they focus your work and provide direction, helping you decide what sources are worth gathering and analyzing.¹¹ Historical questions focus on past events, people, communities and locations, with a particular

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attention to understanding how and why things change over time. Historical questions can be framed in different contexts and time scales. Exploring the topic of the arrival of a new group in the population could be explored in the context of residences and neighborhoods, work and business, education, community organizations and family. Considering the topic in those contexts leads to questions about where the new group lived, where they worked and what businesses they established, where their children went to school, what organizations and events they joined and established, who they married and how many children they had. Those questions could be posed for time frames such as the years immediately after the group arrived, for the first generation, or the second generation, or across multiple generations.

Topics in the history of a place also need to be considered in terms of the larger context of the surrounding places, the region, and the nation. To do local history is to “toggle between the immediate peoples and conditions of a place and the mounting and pervasive influences of state, nation, and society at large.”¹² For example, did a new group that arrived in your place also settle in surrounding places, or in other places in the region or nation? Did they arrive in other places at the same time? Did their experience in other places differ from their experience in your place? Did connections exist between the groups in these places? To explore the relation between a place that is the subject of local history and the surrounding communities and broader context means recognizing that those relationships change. As Joseph Amato argues, “localities begin as part of and are progressively incorporated into regions.... These interconnections are the consequences of the increased penetration of commerce, capital, and labor; the monumental expansion of transportation and communication systems; the heightened integration of government, law, and bureaucracy; and the spread and imposition of literacy, schools, drafts, and popular and political cultures.”¹³

The topic of major events has the advantage of offering a ready connection between a local setting and larger historical issues. You can ask questions about local perspectives and experiences of major events such as wars, depressions, national or state elections, assassinations, epidemics, or natural disasters. This is a particularly useful approach to the history of a place in the twentieth century, when localities are increasingly integrated, and history is regarded as a national rather than local. So while the decisions about World War 2, for example, were made outside local communities, questions can be asked about who went to war, how their families fared, what women did in the war effort, who did not participate or resisted service,

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why the community responded in varying ways, and how the population and environment changed during and after the war.¹⁴ Answers to those questions can be compared with those for surrounding communities, and with state and national patterns.

In developing questions about major events, it's worth bearing in mind what David Gerber argues are the limits of this approach. "Because events, even when recurring, are not continuous through time, we do not get a picture of the full range of interactions between localities or communities and the world beyond them. In addition, because the localities and communities are responding to externally initiated events, they appear more or less passive in relation to forces outside them; thus we are denied a sense of the dynamic interactions between those forces and the communities or localities with which they interact."¹⁵ Gerber favors a focus on "social processes, such as urbanization, industrialization, social mobility or immigrant assimilation." "Social processes impact more generally throughout society than do epic events," but "almost always vary to one extent or another in shape, content, and consequence from place to place and community to community within that society."¹⁶

Research questions frequently change during the process of doing research; what you find refines your question.¹⁷ In Jill Lepore's analogy, "A question isn't a fish, a very wise historian once said; it's a fishing license. It says what kind of fish you're looking for, and where you're going to put your boat. Never go fishing without a license. Once you're got that license, sail into the wide water, and cast your line."¹⁸ To catch the fish you need, you have to cast your line repeatedly; in that sense, historical research is an iterative process, evolving as your knowledge, your catch, grows.

Much of what is written about formulating historical questions is directed at students and academic historians, who face requirements and audiences different from those of local historians. A number of how-to guides to local history published in the 1980s and 1990s, as part of the outline of historical research practices they offered, included sets of questions tailored to local historians. This table draws on those lists and is intended, as Kyvig and Marty put it, "to clarify the range of opportunities and to suggest specific possibilities."¹⁹ It provides paths from a topic to a question, and from a general question to a more specific question. It also includes an overview of the sources that can be used to answer those questions. You can also reverse how you read the table; you can begin with the sources you have, and explore the topics they contain and the questions that they can be used to answer. Subsequent modules will

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explore how you locate those sources, and how you analyze them and understand the information they provide and the answers it offers to your questions.

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TOPICS	QUESTIONS	SOURCES
EVENTS	Crisis - epidemic, natural disaster: how did the community respond, who were the leaders, what institutions were created²⁰	Newspapers Maps Census Government records Letters & diaries
	Civil War / WW1/ WW2 / Vietnam War: - Who went to war, how did their families fare, what did women do in the war effort, who did not participate or resisted service, why did the community respond in varying ways, and how did the population and environment change during and after the war?²¹ - What ties with military or service organizations were maintained once active duty ended? What use was made of veterans' benefits?²² Nineteenth Amendment (Women's Suffrage): - Who was for suffrage, who was against it, and did they express their displeasure? Was the local fight fought on the same grounds as the national battle? Was the leadership local or from outside the community? Did new voters change local politics?²³	Newspapers Census schedules Memorials Veterans Organization records Military service records Pension records Letters & diaries
	- Did your town ever suffer a serious economic downturn? What happened, and how was it reversed (if it was)? - Have there ever been any major failures—of businesses or banks—that affected your town? What were the repercussions?	Newspapers Letters & diaries
COMMUNITIES <i>A company or business:</i>	- how and why a company was founded, by who, how it expanded its operations (or failed to do so), how its management structure and style evolved, how it interacted with competitors, how it found a market for its products²⁴ - why was the location chosen - were the founders local, were local labor conditions a factor, was the connection to communications and transportation a factor?²⁵ - who worked for firm? Did it change - how and why? What impact did it have on community - did it try to train, educate and even control workers? Did it give opportunities to disadvantaged, minorities? - How did business leaders work with community leaders? What trade associations did firm belong to? When did they join? Did they take a leading role?²⁶	Printed histories (on occasion of anniversaries) - pamphlet, book, newsletter, featured in newspaper, in county histories - records in firm's offices, or in local libraries or historical societies - annual reports, advertising, photos, papers of businessmen Legal records - contracts, litigation - accounting records - ledger books -- reveal customers, cots, supplies & suppliers - marketing & advertising = distribution, where sold, who purchased

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		Workers might not be in company records, so check newspapers, census schedules, city directories²⁷ Census of manufactures Reports of government regulatory agencies Court decisions and records Credit reporting agencies
<i>Organizations</i> - Religious groups and denominations - Branches of children's organizations (Scouts etc) - Fraternal, civic, patriotic, charitable, professional, recreational, social, political, or similar voluntary membership organizations - Cultural institutions (museums, libraries, theaters, performance groups, broadcasting stations, publications, and festivals)	• Who created, who led, who joined, who left (& why) • What were goals, what conflict (& how resolved), what are they proud of, what traditions has it claimed? • When did it begin, when did it experience dramatic changes in membership, when did it take new directions, when have significant leadership changes taken place, when has it celebrated significant milestones? • Where did members come from, where did it build, where did members spend their time, where were its most powerful competitors? • How has it expressed its beliefs in practices, how has power been distributed, how has it made decisions, how has it spent its money, how has it responded to social changes & changes in the community / neighborhood, how has it told its story²⁸ • What sorts of performances, parades, lectures, exhibitions, or other activities have these institutions held over the years? • How has the organization felt and acted toward other groups and the community as whole?²⁹	Official documents - deeds, constitution, mortgages - fundraising brochures and anniversary booklets - records of pastoral acts - baptism, wedding, burial, financial records, minutes of board/ decision-making body & other groups - official reports to denomination [for patterns of growth and organization, decisions, leaders] - publications (newsletters, magazines etc), writings by leaders, worship/service bulletins [for attendance, giving, hymn preferences and sermon topics and texts - for shifts in workshop practice] - Buildings Letters & diaries
<i>Education</i> - Public, private and parochial schools - Preschools, colleges - Trade and business schools, adult evening classes	• When did formal education appear? In what ways did it grow and change? When did it go through major periods of growth and change? What sort of educational opportunities became available, and what sort disappeared? Who was responsible for founding schools or changing them? • When were specific buildings built, remodeled, sold or destroyed? How were the buildings used? • Administration: Who? How was educational policy determined? • What was mission of the institution? What was the degree to	Published sources --institutional course catalogues, faculty and student handbooks --publications of professional organizations of educators - newsletters, journals -- reports of institutions, governing bodies, statistics

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	which it achieved its goals? Was the preferred form of discipline harsh or gentle? How did the disciplinary process fit with the mission of the institution? When and in what ways did discipline change? • What was the form of learning?³⁰ • Who attended different institutions? For how long? Did more girls or boys attend? Which groups quit early or never attended? Did attendance vary at different times of year? Did those patterns change? • Did all groups have the same curriculum, discipline, teachers, extracurriculum, and treatment? • What became of the students? • Who taught, and for how long? When, how and why did women come to dominate? At what age did teachers begin? What was expected of teachers? What role did they have in the community? How did the institution respond to good or bad teachers?³¹	gathered by state education departments, records of parent=teacher organizations³² Textbooks, yearbooks, ephemera such as report cards, diplomas, merit awards, trophies, bells, mascots and insignia, playground equipment, classroom equipment Newspapers Maps Buildings Photographs (buildings, students, staff, events) Census Letters & diaries Manuscript sources - Minutes of board of trustees, public school board³³
<i>Work</i>	• What did most people in your town do for work 50/100/150 years ago?³⁴ Why did their work change or stay the same?	Census Newspapers City directory Letters & diaries
<i>Population</i>	• Which Native American tribes lived in your area? What happened to them?³⁵ • When and why did different ethnic and racial groups arrive in your community? What institutions did they establish? Did they provoke a hostile reaction - in what form? What festivals etc did they observe? • Was slavery ever legal in your town? When? If it was, how many enslaved people lived in the area, and what kind of work did they do? Why did the law change when it did?³⁶	Census Newspaper Maps Legal records Letters & diaries
<i>Crime</i>	• What were the most common crimes 50/100/150 years ago, and how were they handled?³⁷ • How did patterns of crime compare with national norms? • Who have been the police? Who have been the criminals?³⁸	Court records Newspapers Police records Local government records Prison records Buildings - courthouse, prison, police station Photographs

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<i>Politics</i>	• What political issues and movements have arisen in the community? • How and why have they aroused, divided, or united individuals, neighborhoods, or groups within the community? • What have been the patterns of participation and preference in elections? • How have defeated individuals and groups responded and been treated?³⁹	Newspapers Organization records Letters & diaries
FAMILIES	• Who was considered to be a member of the family? How many children were part of the family? Was the birth of children evenly spaced, planned, or unexpected? Where were children born? • Where did the family live? Did they move? • If friends, boarders, or servants lived with the family, who were they, why were they there, what was expected of them, and how were they treated? • Did elderly persons live in their own homes, with their children, in retirement communities, or in old-age homes? • If related families lived in the same neighborhood or community, what was the nature of their interaction with one another? • Did family members who had moved away return to the family home for visits or extended residence?⁴⁰	Census: tabulations over time & schedules Cemeteries Houses Maps Letters & diaries
<i>Children</i>	• What role, if any, did family members or outsiders—friends, neighbors, professionals—play in birth, adoption, and childcare? • Why and how did relationships between parents and children change as people aged? • What were the family's attitudes and experiences with adoption, foster care, institutionalization? • What level of schooling did family members achieve? • What schools did they attend, and how did they get there? • Did they serve apprenticeships, undergo special training in the military, or obtain other types of education? If they went to college, how did they finance it and what did they study? • What clubs and activities did children participate in?⁴¹	Census Photographs Newspaper Organization records Military records Letters & diaries
<i>Family events</i>	• How has the family's diet and clothing changed over the years? • How did changing technology affect the family; that is, when and how did such things as piped water and fuel, electricity, telephones, cars and trucks, radios, vacuum cleaners, refrigerators, televisions, microwave ovens, computers, cell phones, and so forth come into use, and what impact did they have? • What kind of family celebrations and reunions were held? • What holidays and special occasions were observed, and how? • In what kinds of social activities did the family engage?⁴²	Photographs Recipe books Newspapers Letters & diaries

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<i>Family activities</i>	• How did members of the family earn a living? • What was the nature and extent of military service by family members? • To what extent were family members involved in community affairs, charitable activities, reform movements, or local government? • How and why did they or did they not participate? • How, if at all, did they benefit from being socially or politically active? • How and why did the pattern of participation change from generation to generation?	Census Newspapers Organization records Letters & diaries
<i>Marriage</i>	• Who married – where did they come from, how did a couple meet, how did courtship occur, at what age? • What ceremonies, rituals (including gifts and honeymoons) accompanied marriage? • Who divorced, when, for what reasons, with what consequences? • Did these practices change across generations? If so, why?	Newspaper marriage announcements Legal records Letters & diaries
<i>Sickness & death</i>	• Who cared for sick, aged, orphaned, disabled, or dependent family members? • What were the family's practices in the event of a death? • Where, if anyplace, were family members buried? • Who inherited what?⁴³	Cemeteries Legal records Organization records Letters & diaries Letters & diaries
LOCATIONS	• Why was your town settled?	
<i>Residences</i>	• When was the building built? What was its architectural style? • What were its dimensions? How many rooms (and of what size and nature) did it contain? Were bathrooms an original feature, a later addition, or missing? Why? • Did the building have porches or balconies? • Was it one of a kind, similar in style to others in the community, identical to others in the neighborhood constructed at the same time? • Did it ever undergo substantial remodeling or expansion? When? How? Why? • How was sleeping, living, and working space arranged? • How was the building heated, cooled, and illuminated? Did the building have fireplaces, indoor plumbing, electricity, or other features? • How was the house or apartment decorated and furnished? How was the kitchen equipped? • How much property surrounded the building, and how was it used (farm, yard, garden, parking, business)? What is the history of other structures on the property? • Who lived in the building?	Maps Town Plans Newspapers Photographs City directories - names, addresses, occupations, sometimes race, information on ownership, businesses -plat maps [shape, size, legal descriptions and ownership of land] - surveyors notes [descriptions of flora and terrain] - deeds (at county courthouse) - arranged sequentially = chain of property owners = names, residences - can include birth, marriage, divorce, death of owners - also can identify restrictions on use of property

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	• Was it owner occupied or rented? • Was it used for any purposes other than housing? • When and how did ownership of the property change? • Did owners and tenants have conflicts? • Did local government agencies ever inspect or condemn the property? • Was it ever seized for nonpayment of taxes or mortgages?⁴⁴	- mortgages, liens - tax records - name of owner, assessment value - improvements to property like remodeling, pools - building permits - details of construction, plans, public utility - court records = law suits, wills & probate inventory of property, divorce⁴⁵ - Letters & diaries
<i>Public places</i> - federal presence - post offices - city halls, courthouses, capitols - cultural institutions - churches, schools, libraries, museums - market places, commercial structures, accommodations	• who built, why, when planned & completed, who designed • public aspects - relation to street & immediate surroundings, what makes it part of group, what makes it monumental or landmark, how do passers-by relate to it, how is it connected to community as a whole • private aspects - what makes it unique, how used & adapted over years, how was it financed, what is its style, does it say anything about a particular person or group • people dimension - how does structure manage people or influence their behavior, does it isolate people or bring them together • site & situation - how does it fit into community plan, has physical geography influenced the structure, relationship to transportation, was it affected by zoning laws • - time dimensions - has community around structure changed, has site or structure reflected changes, has it been remodeled⁴⁶ • What were the most significant development projects to take place in your town? When did they happen? Were they contested?⁴⁷	- Maps - Photographs - Plans - Newspapers - Letters & diaries
<i>Monuments</i>	• History • Design • Materials • Site • Inscriptions • Connections (with other people, places & times) • Subsequent life⁴⁸	- Maps - Photographs - Plans - Newspapers
<i>Neighborhoods</i>	• How is the neighborhood defined? • What, if anything, is its central focus? • What are its boundaries, and what distinguishes it from adjacent areas? • How and why have the size, shape, and image of the neighborhood changed over the years?	- Census - Maps - Newspapers - Buildings - Letters & diaries

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	• What sorts of structures and open spaces could be found in the neighborhood at various stages in its history? • Was it built up over a period of years or developed as one coherent project? • How is the nature of its development evident? • How and why have architectural styles varied or remained the same? • Where did residents go to work, shop, obtain services, worship, and seek entertainment or recreation? • How did they travel? How easy or difficult was it to move beyond the neighborhood? • What have been the important institutions in the neighborhood (parks, union halls, churches, taverns, libraries, theaters, sporting venues, stores, office buildings, shopping malls, schools, hospitals, factories, prisons, others), and what has been their role in the neighborhood's history? • Who has lived in the neighborhood? • What family or other ties linked various households? • What groups (ethnic, religious, occupational, or social) and economic classes have been represented? In what proportions? • How has this situation changed over time? Has one dominant group been replaced by another? Have various groups clashed? • What caused people to move into and out of the neighborhood? • How and why have events, activities, or problems brought residents of the neighborhood together, if at all? • Have there been neighborhood parties, festivals, parades, or other celebrations?⁴⁹	
<i>Infrastructure</i>	• When did paved roads, telephones, electricity, streetlights, water, trash collection and disposal arrive – and who got it?⁵⁰ • What forms of transportation served your town – canals, railroads, highways, airports, buses, trams?⁵¹ When and why were they introduced and discontinued? Where were they located?	Maps Town plan Government records Letters & diaries Newspapers
<i>Environment</i>	• Are there flora and fauna that used to grow in your town that are now gone? Conversely, does the area now have any common flora and fauna that weren't around 50 years ago?⁵² • How has the natural situation, the atmosphere, air and water quality, climate, terrain, and presence or absence of natural resources changed over time? • How have these factors influenced the allocation of space and the design of buildings? • How have they affected family, neighborhood, and community	Maps Town plan Photographs Letters & diaries

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NOTES

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¹² Amato, "The Extraordinary Ordinary and the Changing Face of Place," 17.

¹³ Amato, 17.

¹⁴ Kammen, *On Doing Local History*, 2014, 47–48.

¹⁵ David A. Gerber, "Local and Community History: Some Cautionary Remarks on an Idea Whose Time Has Returned," *The History Teacher* 13, no. 1 (1979): 24, <https://doi.org/10.2307/492007>.

¹⁶ Gerber, 24–25.

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- ²⁰ Carol Kammen, *On Doing Local History: Reflections on What Local Historians Do, Why, and What It Means* (Nashville, Tenn: American Association for State and Local History, 1986), 106.
- ²¹ Kammen, *On Doing Local History*, 2014.
- ²² Kyvig and Marty, *Nearby History*, 1982.
- ²³ Kammen, *On Doing Local History*, 2014, 47-48.
- ²⁴ K. Austin Kerr, Amos J. Loveday, and Mansel G. Blackford, *Local Businesses: Exploring Their History*, The Nearby History Series 5 (Nashville, Tenn: American Association for State and Local History, 1990), 21.
- ²⁵ Kerr, Loveday, and Blackford, 24.
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- ²⁷ Kammen, *On Doing Local History*, 2014, 46.
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- ³⁰ Butchart, *Local Schools*, 16-18.
- ³¹ Butchart, 24, 27.
- ³² Butchart, 51-55.
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- ³⁴ Rebecca Onion, "What Happened Here?," *Slate*, August 20, 2015, http://www.slate.com/articles/life/history/2015/08/local_history_join_slate_s_rebecca_onion_on_a_quest_to_learn_more_about.html.
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